

Written Communication:
Writing an essay interpreting
Chinua Achebe's "Civil Peace"

Style manuals across disciplines for higher research writing

- For technical and scientific research writing:
 - a) IEEE (Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers) manual
 - b) APA (American Psychological Association) manual

For Social Sciences and Humanities

- a) MLA Handbook
- b) Chicago Style Manual
- c) Harvard Style Manual
- d) APA Style Manual

Templates drawn from Gerald
Graff and Cathy Berkenstein's
*They Say, I Say: The Moves that
Matter in Academic Writing*

Introduction: How to begin?

Beginning with a Debate

- a. In discussing Chinua Achebe's views on Nigeria's common populace, one often claims _____ (Arthur, 86). On the one hand, _____ argue _____ (Ghosh and Sen, 87). On the other hand, _____ contends _____ (John et.al., 92). Others even maintain _____ (Robin and Swami, 79). My own view is _____. This is exemplified in Achebe's short story "Civil Peace" which has a war survivor struggling to live in times of peace. He is _____.

(Whenever you cite or borrow from others, provide reference in parenthesis by following norms of the style manual who are working with)

Stating your position:

b. I've always believed that colonization has had its merits and demerits. When I was a child, I believed _____. Reading Achebe's short story, "Civil Peace" I cannot help thinking that _____. At the same time, I believe _____ and also _____.

Referring to critical sources:

c. A number of scholars have suggested that Achebe's views on colonial Nigeria is _____. It has become common today to state _____. In their recent work A and B claim _____.

(Remember to make citations as you proceed).

Summary of your main argument and the use of quotations

- Chinua Achebe hails the survival instinct within humanity, and his hero Jonathan Iwegbu presents a glorious example of survivor hood by _____. Iwegbu reminds us that _____. He admits: "_____". Accordingly, I reaffirm _____.

Body of the Essay: Possible Positions

When you disagree with existing ideas and give reasons for it:

- The scholar A is mistaken about Chinua Achebe because she ignores the fact that _____.
- I disagree with A's view that _____ because recent studies on Achebe's works have revealed _____.

When you agree with existing ideas and continue by adding your own take:

- I agree that scholar X's views on human tragedies that they sometimes embitter people. This is because my own experience at ____ confirms it.
- X's theory on Achebe's worldview is extremely useful here because it sheds light on _____. This helps me understand _____.

When you agree and disagree simultaneously:

- Though I concede _____, I still insist that Achebe's views were _____.
- While Achebe is perhaps too idealistic when he states _____ he is right when he _____.

Remaining undecided:

- I am on two minds about Achebe's take on colonial governance. On the one hand I agree that _____ On the other hand, I am not sure whether _____
- My feelings on "Civil Peace" are mixed. I do support Jonathan for _____, but I find his actions in _____ and the problems he faces equally justifiable.

Toward a Conclusion

Use transitions:

- As a result
- After all
- In short
- Finally
- To summarize
- In sum
- Simply put

Concluding Section: Repeat yourself but differently this time

1) In sum, my argument is _____.

2) To conclude, I would like to reiterate that Jonathan Iwegbu is heroic because he _____ and what Achebe claims as _____ is relevant even today for _____.

3) By realistically depicting the perils Jonathan Iwegbu and his family experience, Achebe us _____ and I believe this reaffirms the age-old philosophy that _____.

- QUIZ 1 (Exam 1): Sept 19, 2025, Friday
- Time: 12.00 noon to 1.00 pm
- Mode: Through hard copies, class assignment
- Students are to answer the exam from the classroom, that is, from the LHC-4
- Multiple choice type questions; no negative marking
- Quiz questions will be taken from the general content of lectures delivered in class.
- No specific questions from short stories
- There will also be comprehension passages with questions